PERKALATE / RETAIL

Measuring In Store Offers: Viewed, Claimed, Redeemed

How physical stores can tell whether a promotion actually brought people in, using three simple numbers and a fair comparison.

Online brands can track almost every click. Physical stores usually can't, which is why so many in store promotions are judged by feel: "It seemed busier." That's not enough to decide whether to run an offer again or how much to put behind it.

You don't need complicated tools to do better. You need three numbers, a fair comparison, and a little patience.

Viewed: did people see it?

Start with reach. How many eligible people saw the offer? For a window sign, you can only estimate from foot traffic. For a digital offer, the count should come from the tool you used to send it.

If views are low, nothing further down matters yet. Move the offer to where your customers already look, or widen who's eligible.

Claimed: did they want it?

A claim is a deliberate step: saving the offer to a phone, tapping a button, scanning a code. It tells you the offer was interesting enough to keep.

If plenty of people saw it but few claimed it, look at the offer itself. Is the reward worth a trip? Is the window too narrow? Can the terms be explained in one sentence?

Redeemed: did they come in?

Redemption is the number that matters most for a store, because it means someone physically walked through your door and bought something. Record redemptions with the date and hour so you can see whether the offer moved traffic into the times you wanted.

If claims are healthy but redemptions are low, the barrier is usually in the visit itself: the offer expired before people got around to it, it was awkward to use at the register, or staff didn't recognize it.

Compare against a normal week

Raw redemptions overstate impact, because some of those people would have come in anyway. To get a fairer read:

- Compare sales in the targeted hours against the same hours in recent weeks without the offer.
- If you can, hold back part of the eligible audience and compare their visits with the group that got the offer.
- Watch the hours around the offer window. If traffic just shifted from Tuesday evening to Tuesday afternoon, you moved visits rather than adding them. That can still be worth it if it eases a crowded period.

Count the second visit

The real payoff from a store promotion is often the visit after the one it paid for. Track whether customers who redeemed came back within the next month. Even a rough count from your point of sale or staff notes is useful.

What to expect early on

The first campaign is for learning. Expect modest numbers, especially if the audience is narrow and the window is short. Look for the shape of the funnel and whether redemptions cluster in the hours you targeted. Plan on adjusting the reward, the window or the audience two or three times before you settle on a version worth repeating.

Write down the cost of each campaign: total reward value redeemed plus any extra staff time. Compare it with the margin on the added visits. That's your answer on whether to keep going.

Measuring without collecting personal data

None of this requires knowing who each customer is. Aggregate counts by stage and by hour answer the important questions.

Three numbers and an honest comparison will tell you more than a busy feeling ever will.

Plan a pilot

Choose one audience, one reward and one result to measure. Set the budget and eligibility rules before launch. Tell participants which information you need and share results in aggregate where possible.